Back to Jerusalem

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By Luis Bush

Introduction

- Napoleon said: "When China is moved, it will change the face of the globe." One hundred years later Christian author and former Time Magazine Beijing Bureau chief David Aikman writes a book titled Jesus in Beijing: How Christianity Is Transforming China and Changing the Global Balance of Power. The move has begun. It is now taking place.
- "Asia is the greatest theatre of the Twentieth Century…. China has impressed me more than any other nation I have visited… . The Chinese have the characteristics of the great races of the world: industry, frugality, patience, tenacity, great physical vigor, great intellectual power, independence, and conservatism. These are the great qualities which have marked off the great races of the world, and the Chinese possess them in a wonderful degree… under the transforming, directing, and energizing power of the Holy Spirit, one of the mightiest forces for the upbuilding of the kingdom of God. Their influence is destined to be increasingly felt far beyond the limits of the Middle Kingdom." —John R. Mott, in *China's Millions*.

As time allows, following an outline with words beginning with C for China in the English language, briefly considering these questions in a desire to understand what God would have is to do in our time together. Your answers to the World Inquiry regarding the Back to Jerusalem movement are interwoven in the course of considering the Back to Jerusalem movement—

[Call – Challenges – Connections – Concerns – Capabilities – Crisis – Commitment – Collaboration – Covenant]

Call of the Back to Jerusalem movement

- The vision goes back to the late 1920s, when a group called the Jesus Family had formed in China. They lived like the church in Acts 2, sharing all their possessions in a common pool, and preaching the gospel as they walked from one village to another.
- An early thrust to the vision came when God gave a clear call to a small group of Christians studying at the Northwest Bible Institute in Shaanxi Province in the early 1940s.
- A business meeting was held on May 15, 1946 at which a constitution was accepted and Officers elected, thus formally organizing the Back to Jerusalem Evangelistic Band. Some of the extracts of the Constitution included that this was an inter-denominational but not an anti-denominational group of workers accepting the whole Bible as God's revelation. Its aim was to join members of the Lord's body in fellowship to consecrate strength and will on the preaching of the Gospel in order to be ready for the Lord's return. The sphere of the prioritized on pioneer work is the seven provinces on the borders of China: Xinjiang, Inner Mongolia, Tibet, Xikang [Tibetan areas of today's western Sichuan], Qinghai, Gansu, Ningxia and in the seven countries on the borders of Asia: Afghanistan, Iran, Arabia, Iraq, Syria, Turkey and Palestine.

- The vision appeared to die for about 30 years during times of great hardship and persecution of the church in China, before God resurrected it among the current generation of churches in the 1980s.
- The vision became widely accepted and established in China as a result of a unifying meeting with Christian leaders in China in 1996.

To the World Inquiry question related to the Back to Jerusalem movement answered by many of you: What is God calling His People to do?

	Sum %
• Church planting movements within all people groups	47
• Preach the gospel to every person through personal evangelism	25
• Scriptures available in every language	15
• Seek social transformation	11
• Develop regional and global partnerships	8

Challenges to the Back to Jerusalem movement

Major External Challenges

	Sum %
• Unreached ethnic people groups	20
• Religious fundamentalism (Islam)	19
• Injustice	17

These three major challenges combined 56% of the total weighted possible response out of sixteen questions from the combined World Inquiry responses from those at this event.

Those three major external challenges to the Back to Jerusalem movement are all directly and mostly related to the challenge of Islam. Lets elaborate for few moments on this most important core challenge facing the Back to Jerusalem movement.

Interestingly it came to founder of the initiative and the name back to Jerusalem in the early 1940's Mark Ma immediately after he received the call from God.

The booklet entitled *The Chinese back-to-Jerusalem Evangelistic Band: A Prayer Call to Christian Friends of the Chinese Church*, published in 1946, offers several insightful entries regarding this challenge and the response to it.

Response to the Challenge:

- On the morning of May 23, 1943 . . . I said to the Lord, "That section of territory is under the power of Islam and the Muslims are the hardest of all peoples to reach with the gospel."
- The Lord replied, "The most rebellious people are the Israelites, the hardest field of labor is my own people the Jews." . . . . The Lord continued speaking, "Even you Chinese, yourself included, are hard enough but you have been conquered by the gospel."
- I asked, "O Lord, if it is not that their hearts are especially hard, why is it that missionaries from Europe and America have established so many churches in China but are still unable to open the door to Western Asia?"

Exactly one week ago today, on June 30, a consultation of thirty Christian leaders mostly from Muslim majority countries, some from the more difficult and dangerous places to be a Christian in the world today gathered together to discuss the contexts and the situations facing the Christian leaders from all around the world, and in particular, the effects of Islam on the Church

The challenge of Muslim majority countries are great for the Back to Jerusalem movement:

- Because those are the majority of countries on their route back to Jerusalem,
- Because those Islamic Majority countries are where you have the highest level of Christian persecution in the world today,
- Because of the Islamic plans for expansion. One leader told of some Muslims are seeking to build a mosque every 15km, starting in Khartoum, Sudan and proceeding all the way to Capetown, South Africa.
- Because of the heightened levels of uncertainty with regards to the Middle East, and the possibility that situations facing the Church could mean, as one leader suggested, that
- "yesterday was better than today, and today could be better than tomorrow."

The challenge from Islamic, mainly Arab countries presents both a challenge and an opportunity which comes 3) from a secular report that highlights the staggering need facing the Arab world is the 2003 UN Human Development Report on the Arab World. The reports' findings really speak for themselves:

- The cumulative GDP of 22 Arab States is LESS than the GDP of Spain;
- 65 million of Adults in the Arab world (two thirds of whom are women), are illiterate;
- 10 million children in this region do not attend school;
- Arab countries have the highest unemployment rates of any in the world (15% -- in reality, this could be more);
- Only 1.6 % of Arab World have internet access;
- This region also has the world's lowest number of telephones, PC's and websites per capita;
- Religious, social, and political freedom is the lowest in this area than anywhere else in the entire world.

These are sobering realities. It is a difficult area. The problems are complex.

Response of Mark Ma to the challenge of the Muslim world that morning in May of 1943 – would it be the same for different today came out of a conviction birthed out of a time of prayer with God according to the 1946 booklet?

- I said to the Lord, "That section of territory is under the power of Islam and the Muslims are the hardest of all peoples to reach with the gospel."
- The Lord answered me, "It is not that their hearts are especially hard, but I have kept for the Chinese church a portion of inheritance, otherwise, when I return will you not be so poor?
- When I heard the Lord say He had kept for us a portion of inheritance, my heart overflowed with Thanksgiving and my mouth uttered many Hallelujahs! I stopped arguing with the Lord.

- On that morning of May 23 1943 as I fasted and prayed about the name of the Band the Lord revealed the verse of Scripture to my heart, “This gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world, for a witness unto all nations; and then the end shall come” (Matt. 24:14).
- They decided they needed a name for their group and settled on Bian Chuan Fuyin Tuan, which literally means the “Preach Everywhere Gospel Band”. This is the name this small group of faith-filled men and women are known by in China to this day, but the missionaries agreed that the English name of the movement should be the “Back to Jerusalem Evangelistic Band”.
- At the meeting Mark Ma told his small group of fellow enthusiasts that God was calling Chinese evangelists and missionaries not just to the outlying provinces of China, including Xinjiang and Tibet, but to Afghanistan, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Syria, Turkey, and Palestine (which at the time was still a British man date territory). It probably didn’t seem too unusual a challenge to some of the group.
- In prison Mecca Chao had a vision—a map of Ningxia, the Chinese province that held a large number of Muslims in it. In 1947 he was freed from prison and found his way to the Northwest Bible Institute. It was here that Pastor Mark Ma explained the significance of the word “Mecca” to him.
- As we read these early accounts we are constrained to ask the question How would the Chinese leadership respond to the enormity of the challenge of the Muslim peoples today?
- (especially when we see the interior obstacles within the Body of Christ) The response to the Inquiry of what the major internal obstacles to Back to Jerusalem movement represent are:

Major Internal Obstacles

- Lack of training of workers 20
- Lack of effective leadership 19
- Need for reconciliation among House Church leaders 13

Several of those involved in the process leading up to this event, including a number who are not here, have communicated and have expressed concerns, that there are fairly significant unresolved issues and that it would be difficult to proceed without resolving those issues. That is a sobering thought for us to think about.

Concerns about the Back to Jerusalem movement in the form of questions
Structural/Promotional limitations:

- Foreigners involved in various levels of controversy work within structures that are not traditional mission agencies are forced to tell their story to their constituency for their livelihood.
- More established mission agencies at work in China have distanced themselves from this behavior. Articles have been written because not doing it right whether funding, training, long-term strategies, etc.

Ownership of a vision without authority to do so

- What about the registering of Back to Jerusalem organizations in London, Australia, Singapore, Sweden etc.?

- What about those from China – representing networks inside China; especially if a persons says they are THE rather than A rep.
    - Funding approach should Back to Jerusalem movement be self-funded from within China
    - Funding irregularities
    - Theological Concerns
    - Controlling Concerns
    - Rumor-mongering about Back to Jerusalem, and characters of those who speak for them
    - Those responding to the call from the rural areas and not qualified and so on

Capabilities

- Influence of the nation on the world—
- An Emerging China[1]: China in the 21st century appears poised to reclaim the greatness it enjoyed for thousands of years before it slid into eclipse in the late 1840s. … So throughout this year, USA TODAY will offer an occasional story on contemporary China to illustrate how much has changed and how much remains to be done if this is truly to be "The Chinese Century."
- The Economy: SHANGHAI, April 16 (Xinhuanet)—ING Group, one of the world's leading financial institutions, has predicted an optimistic year for Asia's economic growth in its latest forecast report. The report estimated that the total Asia GDP growth, minus Japan, would reach seven percent, and China's GDP, in particular, would grow by 9.5 percent. "The Chinese economy is booming, and the boom will continue.
- Impact on Global Poverty: Recent World Poll[2] sponsored by a Foundation in Greece involving More than 25,000 people from 175 countries took part in the poll, which published on Monday

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1 "**China finds Western ways bring new woes**, "By David J. Lynch, *USA TODAY*
China is the fastest-growing market for American goods, an ally in the war on terror and, at the same time, an emerging rival to U.S. pre-eminence in Asia. In coming years, its major cities will host the Olympic Games and a World's Fair while its movie, fashion and sports stars attract growing numbers of fans. China in the 21st century appears poised to reclaim the greatness it enjoyed for thousands of years before it slid into eclipse in the late 1840s. Yet Beijing's leaders face daunting challenges. An authoritarian political system that arbitrarily imprisons those with unpopular views demands reform. Economic vitality and growing regional clout coexist with woes that bedevil all developing countries: environmental degradation, poverty and preventable illnesses. Understanding the world's most populous nation has never been more vital. So throughout this year, USA TODAY will offer an occasional story on contemporary China to illustrate how much has changed and how much remains to be done if this is truly to be "The Chinese Century."

2 More than 25,000 people from 175 countries took part in the poll, which published on Monday the findings that poverty, jobs and standard of living (33 percent) and the environment (28 percent) are the two main areas of concern. Terrorism (13 percent) came a distant third. The poll was carried out by the Andreas Papandreou Foundation, a Greek think tank, during the Earth Summit that took place in Johannesburg last September. Phil Noble, whose company PoliticsOnline conducted the study, said: "What really surprised me was the number of countries from where we got respondents. "It shows that the Internet has connected a global political village and there is a real hunger for global participation in

the findings that poverty, jobs and standard of living (33 percent) Nov 2003. WASHINGTON, April 23 (Reuters) - World poverty is falling sharply on the back of China's rising prosperity. The proportion of the developing world's population living in poverty fell by nearly half in the past 20 years -- to 21 percent in 2001 from 40 percent in 1980, the report said. China's economic growth of close to 9 percent per year over the past two decades was mainly responsible for the overall improvement because of the sheer size of its population.

- Church learned lessons of suffering

Crisis: At Beijing Forum those gathered described the situation as a crisis

Commitment

As a Back to Jerusalem Network, we are committed to serve the church in China as it seeks to fulfill its role in the Great Commission; specifically, to fulfill the prophetic mandate of the Back to Jerusalem Movement.

Collaboration

Assistance Needed from Global Evangelical Structures like those here today to Enable and Empower Back to Jerusalem Movement.

	Sum %
• Inspiration and prayer networks	29
• Leadership development	23
• Resource networks	18
• Relationship building / fellowship, networking opportunities	14

BJ2 Tracks:

- Training & Equipping: Help develop contextualized cross-cultural training programs that equip church planters with necessary ministry, personal developmental and economic skills to initiate cross-cultural church planting Movements.

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global issues." Another significant finding was that out of all participants, Europeans were seen as the most pessimistic, with 82 percent of their responses being negative. George Papandreou, Foreign Minister of Greece, said: "This experiment in e-democracy created a unique opportunity for ordinary people to participate in a global debate about the critical issues that affect their daily lives." According to the poll, 71 percent of people are dissatisfied with the state of the global environment -- and 67 percent say it is getting worse.

- Media & Ministry Tools Help provide strategic, effective, appropriate media, & ministry tools that would facilitate the church planting thrust among unreached peoples***Prayer & Mobilization*** Develop an international prayer network to link and serve existing prayer initiatives in China in their growing passion for cross-cultural missionaries among unreached peoples. Logistics & Placement Assist in the practical deployment and work of missionary church planters to various countries and unreached people groups.

Covenant

Open source catalyst organization?

Vision & Mission

Out of the initiative of Chinese Christian collaborate together to empower Chinese Christians to take the gospel back to Jerusalem, and hastening the return of our Lord!

The Mobilization of 100,000 Chinese missionaries for the 10/40 Window by 2050. By including the date we are signaling the importance of moving on the vision immediately. It is urgent. The vision should be accomplished in a short time. We need to ask: How can we support it?

Values

- A vision for all believers. In that so much of Back to Jerusalem is a part of the Great Commission, it is a vision for all believers of all nations to participate in. We acknowledge we cannot achieve the lofty aims of this vision without the help of believers around the world bringing their giftings, information, training and resources as God leads them. We welcome our brothers and sisters from around the world to join us in this vision. At the same time since it a vision given to the Chinese Church, it must be a Chinese led, initiated, and empowered movement, free of foreign control and direction.
- A call to unity around a common goal. It is the Chinese church's desire to avoid all denominationalism both inside China and overseas in the Back to Jerusalem movement. We refuse to be involved with promoting any one denomination or church above another.
- Intercessory prayer is paramount. As the Movement began with prayer we seek to prioritize united, fervent focused prayer. Seek God to have His mind on all aspects of the unfolding vision.
- Revival context. The Back to Jerusalem vision is coming about in a context of the renewal—even revival of the Church in China. "Normal" Christianity for a believer is when we live according to the pattern of the church laid out in the word of God. Spiritual life is the foundation of our Christianity, building up the church is the centre, and the training of workers is the point of breakthrough– the strategic place from where expansion can be carried out in all directions, radiating to every nation and people in the world, so that the ground that the soles of our feet walk on will become our inheritance!
- A vision not an organization. Because Back to Jerusalem is a vision, and not an organization, it will not and cannot be controlled by any one group or church. There does need to be some strategies and planning, but these belong to the whole Body of Christ.

- 6. On our focus. It is the conviction of Back to Jerusalem to send workers to those areas considered the darkest and least hospitable to the Gospel over which the caravan routes came along in the Old Silk Road. There were several routes which cover precisely the region identified today as the 10/40 Window.
- 7. On cooperation among Chinese churches and their leaders. The biggest threat to the Back to Jerusalem movement is clearly division and lack of cooperation among the Chinese churches. Christians from around the world need also to have a commitment for the unity of the Chinese church, a willingness to put aside petty issues and personalities for the sake of the Gospel.
- 8. On collaboration on the field of mission. We do not intend to build on another's foundation, but to simply proclaim the Gospel in word and deed to those lost souls left in the world today. We seek to collaborate as co-laborers in the Gospel with missionaries, existing ministries, national Christians and workers wherever our missionaries go.
- On funding the vision. In areas of finance, the Chinese church should look to the hand of God only for provision, and not depend on outside funding. There may be a time when God leads believers from various places to contribute, but any such gift should always be received, and given, as from the hand of God. This vision has always been one where the Lord has required complete dependence and trust on Him and not on human strength.
- Willingness to suffer. The Chinese church fully realizes that many of the countries in the 10/40 window are hostile to Christian activity. Accordingly, they are sending workers not only willing, but expecting, to suffer and die for the Gospel. We see this in context of their experiences in China these past 50 years, and believe the torture, imprisonment and brutality they have suffered was allowed by God to purify and prepare us for the Back to Jerusalem vision.

Back to Jerusalem UK

We therefore commit ourselves, by God's grace, to serve Back to Jerusalem as appropriate and as we are able. In relating to the Back to Jerusalem movement we are committed as an organization:

- to be supportive
- not to Westernize a Chinese vision
- to serve all mainstream House Church networks
- to be deeply sensitive to felt needs within China
- to share resources and ideas—nothing to be done unilaterally
- to be sensitive to the strategy of the Chinese Back to Jerusalem vision (eg their desire not to build church buildings)
- to not be manipulative
- to ensure that any materials offered are relevant
- to keep a list of cooperative agencies and recognized partners
- to supportive networking in target countries
- that all partnering include being transformed together
- to be sensitive to the existing local churches

- to serve to open up the mission movement of Europe and other parts of
- the world where mission interest is waning.
- to mobilize prayer for Back to Jerusalem
- to financial transparency
- to sensitivity in all security issues
- To take on board principles put to us as a contributing group by the Chinese HC leaders, provided they do not contradict our own Ps&P or core values.

We endeavor to outwork the above principles in the following practical ways:

Resources

- We are ready to share the knowledge and experience of our personnel where possible and appropriate for the advancement of the Back to Jerusalem movement.
- We are ready to share training resources that would benefit the Back to Jerusalem movement.
- While financial resources will not be a major part of our contribution, we will be faithful stewards of funds channeled through W*C for Back to Jerusalem. We will only disburse funds to credible Back to Jerusalem-related ministries. We will establish some basic criteria used to determine what we mean by credible ministries.

Training

- We encourage the sharing of any relevant training resources that could benefit the wider Back to Jerusalem movement (e.g. Operation World, Briefings books, etc.). These will be channeled through Taisto and in fellowship with the Back to Jerusalem Forums so that these resources can be provided in sufficient quantity and be distributed to the widest network of HCs.
- We encourage and support those among us with the gifting and experience (e.g. John Kayser) to produce needed training resources in fellowship with the Back to Jerusalem Forum/HC leaders in order to avoid unnecessary duplication and to ensure relevancy. Resources might include major worldview/religions material, host culture profiles on VCD, etc.
- We encourage CAT members and other suitably gifted workers from outside China to participate in the training of Back to Jerusalem workers both in-country and where appropriate on field locations. Where possible we will utilize the training resources approved by the Back to Jerusalem Forum/HC leaders.
- We ask MTCA to consider positioning itself in such a way that enables it to serve some of the training needs of Back to Jerusalem. (e.g. releasing staff to teach regularly at in-country training centers, receiving appropriate Back to Jerusalem related students who could benefit from courses or mentoring at MTCA on a flexible basis, etc.)

Support

- We encourage our field teams, especially in the 10/40 window, to be ready to pro-actively serve the Back to Jerusalem workers according to need and opportunity. This might include: (i) advising/facilitating visa platforms, or providing visas for Back to Jerusalem workers; (ii) offering orientation to the host culture; (iii) mediating on behalf of Back to Jerusalem workers with officials or other agencies working in the country; (iv) working alongside Back to Jerusalem workers where this is beneficial and mutually desired.
- We will share strategic Back to Jerusalem prayer needs through our prayer networks without compromising the security of Back to Jerusalem workers/ministry.

Coordination

- In order to ensure that we are effective in serving the Back to Jerusalem movement, we will maintain a small Back to Jerusalem Advisory Committee. This committee will operate by email and will be chaired by a Back to Jerusalem Advisor. This committee should include a member from the International Office, and a member of the CAT leadership. This committee should be represented at the London and Singapore.

Chinese Ministry Fellowship (CMF) Principles

- The contributions of all participants are of value; no single individual, church, or organization is put in the spotlight.
- We respect the validity of various approaches to China service and do not discount or seek to discredit the work of others, especially for the purpose of promoting our own work.
- Desiring to be supportive of the whole Body of Christ in China, we refrain from debating the relative merits of working with “official” versus “unofficial” church bodies.
- Out of respect for one another’s theological backgrounds and positions, we seek to situate our discussions within that broad area of common ground which we as Christians share, and we neither promote nor condemn distinctive doctrinal positions.
- Should one participant feel constrained to exhort another regarding a chosen approach or sphere of work, this should be done in a spirit of love and should be handled privately.
- All matters discussed are considered confidential and are not to be shared outside the meeting without prior permission. Nothing is for publication.
- News of upcoming or past meetings, including the names of participants, should not be shared outside the church or organization represented at the meeting; nor should this information be communicated within China or to any representative of Chinese government or a mass organization.
- Participation is by invitation only and participants should not take the liberty of telling others about the meeting, but should instead recommend such persons to the CMF organizers.
- By virtue of their attendance at the meetings, participants agree to be held accountable by their peers for upholding these principles and thus ensuring the integrity of the sharing process.

Covenant from NYCity 2002 event

Back to Jerusalem Network

- As a B2JNetwork we are committed to serve the church in China as it seeks to fulfill its role in the Great Commission; specifically, to fulfill the prophetic mandate of the Back to Jerusalem Movement.
- We are committed to help them as they equip and place Christ-like cross-cultural workers who, in cooperation with the global Body of Christ, are advancing the Kingdom by initiating church planting movements among as yet unreached Han Chinese, all minorities within China and among unreached peoples.
- We seek to demonstrate Christ-likeness by emphasizing the values of:
- Shared vision – Agreed on a definition of success
- Evangelistic – Committed to the Great Commission and the Lausanne Covenant
- Field-driven – Initiative direction set by those on the ground
- Servanthood – We serve one another with mutual respect
- Partnership – International, interactive, and synergistic
- Peaceful – We seek to resolve conflicts in a Biblical manner
- Quiet – In humility, avoiding credit, glory or accolades
- Avoid dependency – Goal to help by serving, not by funding
- Kingdom-centered – Seek to expand the Kingdom, not build our empires
- Fruitful – Seek growth in Christ-like character resulting in church planting movements
- Ethical – Maintain the highest integrity in our financial dealings
- Nurturing – Nurture the network, honoring tracks and team leadership
- Protective – Maintain a low profile and remain sensitive to security issues
- Accountable – Keep each other accountable to values and vision
- Relational – Sensitive to the leading of the Holy Spirit and each other
- Collaborative – Seek the affirmation and collaborative participation of Chinese leaders.

To serve the Lord and this vision, we have organized the B2JNetwork in the following tracks:

- Training & Equipping
  Help develop contextualized cross-cultural training programs that equip church planters with necessary ministry, personal developmental and economic skills to initiate cross-cultural church planting movements.

- Media & Ministry Tools
  Help provide strategic, effective, appropriate media, & ministry tools that would facilitate the church planting thrust among unreached peoples

- Prayer & Mobilization
  Develop an international prayer network to link and serve existing prayer initiatives in China in their growing passion for cross-cultural missionaries among unreached peoples.

- Logistics & Placement
  Assist in the practical deployment and work of missionary church planters to various countries and unreached people groups.